

A Tweak In Time

Bought an LCD, but still can't escape how awful things sometimes look?

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LCDs are quickly becoming mainstream here in India: 19-inch widescreen monitors can be easily found at around Rs 11,000. Let's take a look at what you can tweak, what makes LCDs a must-buy today, and more.

Note: Use the following tweak(s) with care. We are not responsible for any damage that may occur. For any Registry tweaks, back up your Registry before proceeding.

The Field Of View Problem

Most latest games come with resolutions suitable for widescreen monitors. But the issue is with older games, where resolutions of the 4:3 ratio are stretched to the widescreen aspect ratio. The field of view in game changes considerably and your game seems stretched and warped.

If a game has a resolution matching your screen, just go ahead and choose it. For those games that don't have it, you can manually try and force the game to run at a particular resolution. Most games have their resolutions settings in a config file in the installation folder, or in the Registry. You can alter those settings to suit your current resolution.



Quake 3 Arena running at standard 4:3 resolution looks just fine



Quake 3 Arena running at widescreen resolution causes stretching



For example, most *Quake 3*- and *Doom 3*-based games have variables in their config file—such as `r_customwidth = xxxx` and `r_customheight = xxxx`; `r_mode = -1` enables custom resolutions. Make the necessary resolution changes and save the file.

There's even a program called Game Resolution Switcher (<http://grs.mini-info.net/>) which lets you set custom resolutions for a list of games. Another software that lets you set custom resolutions is called Powerstrip—www.entechtaiwan.net/ps.htm.

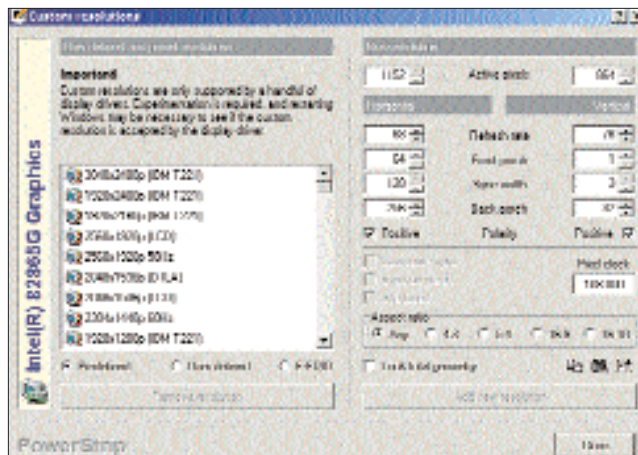
The other way to make things look a bit more normal is to change the Field Of View (FOV). There are some programs and sites that offer FOV calculators that calculate the preferable FOV for widescreens for those who have moved from the standard 4:3 ratio res-

olutions. For games where the default FOV is set at 90 degrees, 16:10 ratio resolution (1280 x 800, 1440 x 900, 1680 x 1050, 1920 x 1200) screen users should set their FOV to around 100 degrees. You may find these variables in the game config files.

Lower Power Consumption By LCDs—No Big Deal?

Some people believe that the lower power consumption of an LCD is overrated and that a cheaper CRT is the way to go. Let's just compare the power consumptions. A typical 19-inch CRT's power rating is set at around 100 W, and a similar-sized LCD, around 30 W. So what type of savings are we talking of here? Say you run a monitor for seven hours a day for a year. A CRT will then consume around 255 kilowatt-hours of power, and the LCD will do around 76. Assuming that 1 unit (1 kilowatt-hour) of power is priced at around Rs 4, the difference in bills between the CRT and LCD over a year is around Rs 700. Multiply that by three years (the common warranty with most monitors), that's over Rs 2,100 saved. If you use your screen for more than seven hours, that translates to a lot more! Keep in mind, the difference in prices for CRTs and LCDs for the 17-inch and 19-inch monitors is really minimal these days.

Also remember, LCDs run at much lower temperatures. If you use an air conditioner in your computer room, the benefits of using an LCD might show up for this reason as well. Let's not forget the glare reduction.



Powerstrip allows you to force resolutions on games

Widescreen—Better Use Of Screen Space?

Widescreen monitors, obviously, have a wider layout. While this means that you'll have to do some amount of vertical scrolling, you can place two windows side by side. It provides a similar way of working to dual-screen setups. Certain LCDs let